John W. Z. Zhang

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Education

Stanford University *Autumn 2026*
Visiting Student Researcher

- Sponsor: Prof. Gary Cox.

London School of Economics and Political Science *Sep 2023 – Autumn 2026*
PhD in Economic History

- Fields: Economic History, Political Economy.
- Supervisors: Prof. Patrick Wallis and Prof. Mohamed Saleh.
- Teaching Assistance: Theories and Evidence in Economic History; The Family Economy in History.

London School of Economics and Political Science *Sep 2022 – Nov 2023*
MSc in Economic History

- Graduated with Merit (70.88%).
- Dissertation ranked 2nd in the cohort (out of 100+).

University of Bath *Sep 2019 – Jul 2022*
BSc (Hons) Economics

- Graduated with First-class honours.
- Dissertation ranked 1st in the cohort (out of 300+).

Job Market Paper

Welfare Retrenchment and Social Unrest 2026

Abstract: Does welfare retrenchment cause social unrest? I study this question using parish-level expenditure on poor relief and data on social unrest in post-Napoleonic England, drawing on the 1818-9 welfare reforms to motivate instrumental variables, regression discontinuity, and event study research designs. The reduced-form analysis finds a causal effect of welfare retrenchment on social unrest between 1816 and 1834, attributable to an exacerbation of relative deprivation that stems from comparisons with higher-expending parishes. Simulations from a counterfactual analysis assuming greater accountability for these grievances highlight the importance of equitable social welfare provision in minimising the political costs of austerity.

Working Papers

Deskilling and Unrest 2026

Abstract: Does deskilling cause unrest? I study this question in the context of the First Industrial Revolution in England, using parish-level data on the adoption of skill-saving machines drawn from a corpus of newspaper advertisements. Reduced-form analysis leveraging an event study research design finds a positive causal effect of skill-saving mechanisation on unrest intensity between 1760 and 1814. Heterogeneity analysis of peaceful collective bargaining and petitioning by employers and workers identifies the weakening of labour market institutions as a plausible mechanism, attributable to the imbalance of lobbying power between winners and losers of disruptive technological change.

Endogenous Revolutionary Threat 2026

Abstract: Does elite conflict cause franchise extension? I study this question in the context of the 1832 Great Reform Act in England, using surviving poll books and parish records on the formation of disenfranchising select vestries. Reduced-form analysis leveraging a difference-in-differences research design finds that political elites residing in parishes with democratic backsliding increased their electoral support for the reformist Whig party between the 1830 and 1831 general elections. I attribute the research findings to the outbreak of the Swing Riots, which occurred with greater intensity in select vestry parishes, providing an elite-conflict interpretation of the theory of revolutionary threat.

Next Release

Austerity Origins of the Great Reform Act 2026

Datasets

Egyptian Parliamentary Speeches, 1924-1952 (with Mohamed Saleh) 2025

Methods: Computer Vision; Generative AI.

Presentations

2026: Theory, History and Development Seminar, University of California, Irvine; Historical Social Science Workshop; Stanford University; Associazione per la Storia Economica Annual Meeting, Milan; Graduate Economic History Seminar, London School of Economics and Political Science; Economic History Association Annual Meeting, St. Louis; Western Economic Association International Annual Conference, Denver; Workshop in Political Economy and Economic History, York; Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy, London; Frontier Research in Economic and Social History Workshop, Berlin; Economic History Society Annual Conference, London; Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.

2025: PPE for Public Policy Graduate Conference, London; Graduate Seminar in Economic and Social History, University of Oxford; Economic and Social History Workshop, University of Cambridge; Graduate Economic History Seminar, London School of Economics and Political Science.

2024: Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.

Other Credentials

Languages: English and Mandarin.

Technical Skills: Julia, MATLAB, Python, QGIS, R and Stata.